When AI Takes Over Every Job, Will Our Job Be to Chase the AI?

Delivery, availability, and permission to leave

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Abstract Suppose AI can write the reports, design the images, and build the software. Does human work then shrink to “Is it done yet?” The answer depends on what completion means: producing an output, meeting delivery conditions, or releasing someone from the obligation to remain available. Beginning with an imagined office mishap, this essay examines four sources of follow-up work: gaps between handoffs, competition for queue position, fragmented availability, and arrangements for responsibility. A scheduling comparison shows that the same 12 minutes of hands-on activity can leave either 48 uninterrupted minutes or a succession of four-minute gaps. Chasing AI may provide valuable coordination, compete for resources, or demonstrate attendance. Even when chasing itself is automated, going home still depends on whether an organization turns productivity gains into time people can control.

1. Three AIs have finished. Why hasn’t the project?

Imagine a highly automated company. Zhou needs only one instruction in the morning: “Prepare next quarter’s promotion for the client meeting this afternoon.” A writing AI prepares the proposal, an image AI designs the poster, and a coding AI builds the campaign page. His title has also changed, from project officer to agent coordination manager. His salary remains unchanged. The title has completed its transformation first.

At ten, all three windows announce completion. The report calculates profit using a 20% discount. The poster advertises 30% off. The page allows another 10% coupon discount on top. Each AI has faithfully followed one of three instructions Zhou issued at different times. Nobody has obviously been idle. Put their work together, however, and the company may need a serious conversation about its post-bankruptcy visual identity.

“Could you check with each other?” Zhou asks. All three reply, “Of course.” The writing AI now awaits the image AI’s final discount; the image AI awaits the page’s final price; the coding AI awaits the approved proposal. Everyone has responded. Nothing has been settled.

Chasing AI now involves real work: establish which requirement is current, withdraw obsolete versions, decide who delivers first, distribute the same rules to all three, and run a complete purchase to verify that the pieces agree. Copying “Hurry up” into three windows would merely deliver reassurance more promptly.

There are three kinds of completion here. **Output completion** means a window has produced something. **Delivery completion** means the pieces jointly meet the agreement. **The end of work**

means Zhou no longer has to remain on call. These states are not automatically connected. AI can accelerate the first while the company leaves one person responsible for the other two.

The first source of a chasing occupation lies in those missing connections. The work might be called coordination, acceptance checking, or exception handling. A job advertisement can cover all three with: “Basic AI skills required. Exceptional sense of responsibility essential.”

2. Does more chasing make the system faster?

To judge whether a reminder helps, ask what it changes. Supplying missing information, withdrawing a mistaken requirement, granting necessary access, or changing a genuine priority can move work forward. Repeatedly requesting the same update, when neither new information nor adjustable resources are available, usually adds communication.

Yet unproductive communication can support a stable job. Imagine that the company has one computing queue, governed by a peculiar rule: whichever pending task was chased most recently goes first. Alice writes “Urgent” and moves ahead. Bob notices he has been displaced, writes “Extremely urgent,” and takes the position back. If actual urgency has not changed, capacity is fixed, and running tasks are not interrupted, the reminders merely redistribute waiting. If each reminder also triggers replanning or rework, total output may fall.

Alice loses by not chasing; so does Bob. Both diligently perform their duties, while the only collective gain may be a larger message count. Eventually, the company introduces a reminder leaderboard, interpreting a shared congestion problem as a difference in employee motivation.

Chasing can therefore benefit an individual without benefiting the system. A job’s existence does not establish that it increases output. Sometimes it only brings one person’s claim on scarce resources forward. Once every request carries the highest priority, priority has one remaining meaning: who can keep typing.

Dealing with this requires deadlines, queue rules, and conditions for escalation. Otherwise, adding an AI to send reminders simply upgrades a competition conducted by people sending two messages a minute into one conducted by machines sending two hundred a second. Output has not risen. Reminder throughput has.

3. Twelve minutes of activity in an hour. Why can’t you go anywhere?

“People can do something else while AI works” assumes they have a sufficiently uninterrupted period that cannot be reclaimed at any moment. If the system can request approval at any time, and a three-minute delay counts as a missed response, waiting is not necessarily rest. A person may be doing nothing at that instant while still selling their availability.

Consider a hypothetical schedule. Twelve checks, each taking one minute, must be performed within an hour. Schedule A starts them at minutes 0, 5, 10, and so on through 55, leaving four minutes after each check. Schedule B groups the checks into the first six and last six minutes. Both require 12 minutes of activity and leave 48 minutes unoccupied. But the longest uninterrupted gap is four minutes in A and 48 minutes in B.

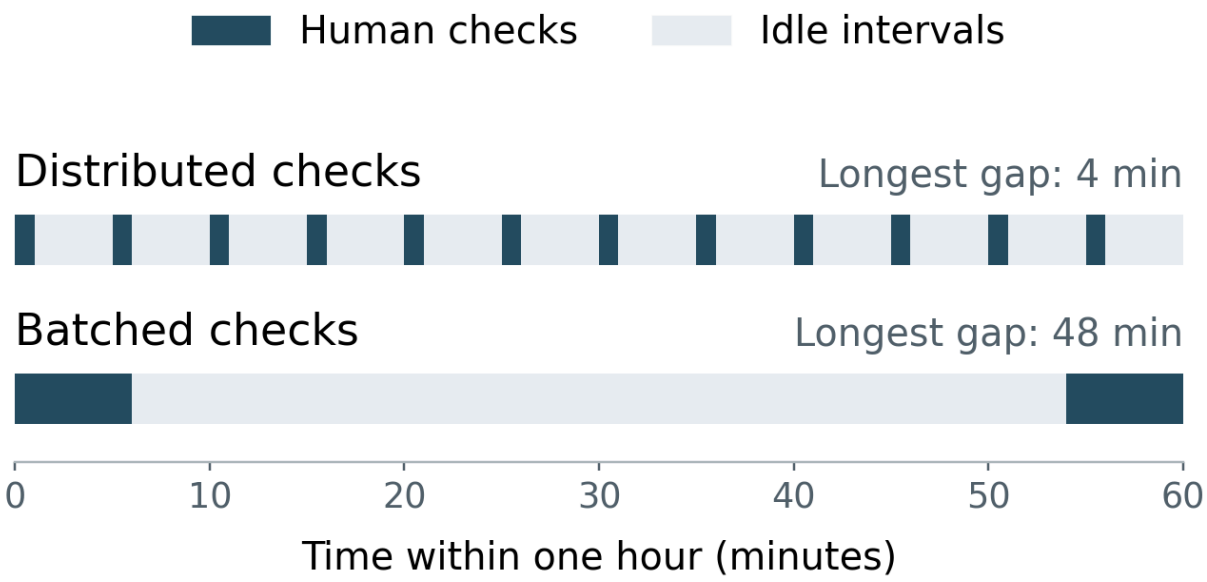


Figure 1: Identical activity time, different uninterrupted gaps: dark intervals are human checks; pale intervals are unoccupied.

Table 1: Hypothetical time allocation within one hour (all values in minutes)

Schedule	Active	Total idle	Longest gap
Distributed	12	48	4
Batched	12	48	48

This comparison assumes the checks can be batched without missing events that require timely action. Urgent alerts cannot be postponed until closing time merely to improve a chart. Nor do these numbers assign an invented price to anxiety or attention recovery. They only separate total idle time from uninterrupted idle time.

Four minutes can be enough to get water, but hardly enough to take a relaxed walk, read a chapter, or settle into another complex task. If ten AIs request attention at staggered times, Zhou may perform little hands-on activity throughout the day while remaining unable to leave. The daily report shows a substantial fall in human time. His experience suggests that the phone has become a wireless tether to his desk.

Evaluating automation therefore requires at least two questions: how much human activity has been removed, and how much uninterrupted time has become freely usable? If only the first improves, work may have moved from doing things to being available whenever called.

4. Why might managing a hundred AIs be harder than managing one?

When each task requires little human intervention, a manager can reach an encouraging conclusion: give Zhou more tasks. Saved time has two possible destinations. It can be returned to the person or exchanged for additional work. The second does not contradict higher efficiency; it converts the gain into output.

The difficulty is that machine production and human checking capacity need not grow at the same rate. Generating ten posters may be cheap; deciding which one meets the client's actual intention still takes time. If every rejection produces ten more, Zhou inherits an expanding backlog of

choices. Making “Generate everything” the default effectively permits the system to add decisions to a person’s desk without limit.

Checking cannot be solved by saying that humans will always provide judgment. You need to understand the pricing, what makes a page usable, and where the evidence might be weak to recognize a fluent but incorrect result. Bainbridge described a related tension in automation: routine operation is delegated, while exceptional takeovers still require proficiency that disuse can erode. That argument arose in industrial control and needs examination before transfer to office work. It nevertheless warns against assuming that removing the training provided by execution will leave an equally capable reviewer. [1]

Output speed alone is also insufficient evidence of productivity. In an early-2025 randomized study, METR had 16 developers complete 246 tasks in open-source projects they knew well. Allowing the AI tools of that period increased completion time by 19%. This was a particular setting at a particular time. The team’s 2026 update reported later results pointing toward speedup, while identifying selection effects and difficulties measuring concurrent work that made its size hard to estimate reliably. The useful lesson is to measure the complete work process, not to turn a percentage into a permanent property of AI. [2], [3]

A useful account would record briefing, constrained waiting, checking, and rework, while avoiding counting freely usable waiting twice as human labor. Count only how quickly machines produce files, and the efficiency report will look excellent. Ask AI to write that report, and it can also explain that Zhou’s exhaustion reflects an insufficiently transformed mindset.

5. Could another AI do the chasing?

Zhou will naturally consider a secretary AI to track progress, chase overdue tasks, collect outputs, and reconcile versions. This can genuinely save work. Mechanical reminders, status summaries, and checks against explicit rules have no inherent claim on a person’s entire day. If chasing becomes humanity’s last occupation, that would look more like a transitional arrangement than a technologically tenured post.

But another supervisor does not necessarily provide another independent source of evidence. If the executing AI and reviewing AI both use obsolete promotion rules, an elaborate review can still approve the wrong version with impeccable consistency. A third AI that checks whether the first two agree merely promotes a shared error into a collective opinion.

Reducing Zhou’s involvement requires defined completion conditions and access to the evidence needed to assess them: which version is valid, whether the tests actually ran, whether delivery reached its destination, which conflicts may be resolved autonomously, and which require escalation. The process also needs a stopping rule. Without one, “Keep improving” can leave an already adequate result permanently in the state of trying hard.

When those conditions are explicit, evidence is verifiable, and risks remain within delegated authority, the chasing chain can end. The system can handle its own handoffs, with the person receiving agreed results or exceptions. Conversely, if the client has not chosen the discount, or budget and performance conflict, stacking more AIs does not conjure an accepted decision.

“Final human approval” also covers two very different arrangements. One provides information, review time, and the right to refuse. The other demands approval within seconds for an incomprehensible result, then asks after a failure: “Didn’t you sign off?” Elish calls attention to the “moral crumple zone,” in which responsibility for an automated system’s behavior may fall on an operator with limited control. Applied to Zhou’s office, the human position may be retained to improve judgment or to supply a convenient person to blame. [4]

Counting the remaining human nodes in a workflow is therefore insufficient. Can that node understand, say no, and be heard when it does? Otherwise, the human is in the loop while the authority is elsewhere.

6. If everyone becomes an AI manager, who pays the managers?

Managing a hundred AIs does not make Zhou the owner of the company. Clients, computing resources, budgets, and the distribution of revenue may remain under somebody else's control. He can choose the wording of a prompt without choosing whether to accept the next order. The number of subordinates has risen sharply. Permission to leave has not been delegated with it.

This is the missing step in the promise that everyone will make a living chasing AI: an activity becomes a paid occupation only if someone will pay for it. Payment might reward fewer failures and more successful deliveries, or compensate someone for remaining continuously available. Discovering that a human can still do something does not establish whether the service is scarce, who funds it, or how much bargaining power the worker has.

If anyone with the same tools can perform ordinary follow-up, while organizations controlling clients and resources need only a few coordinators, universal employment as an AI manager does not follow naturally from technical progress. Lower entry barriers may also increase competition. The ability to chase may command little; the authority to decide what deserves chasing may confer a stronger position.

Future jobs could consequently look alike while differing substantially. One person may define tasks, allocate resources, and reject pointless additions, exercising real decision-making authority. Another may simply stay online, approve requests, and forward exceptions, providing mostly an availability service. Their chat windows could look identical. The shared title "AI manager" would tell us little about their working conditions.

No forecast of future salary scales is needed to distinguish these positions. Ask three concrete questions: can the person refuse tasks, assess the results, and control the time saved by higher efficiency? If all three answers are no, adding "intelligent" to the job title mainly improves the advertisement.

7. Once chasing disappears, why must the human stay?

Push the premise further. AI can reliably execute, coordinate, check results, and handle exceptions within delegated authority. Insisting that humans must still chase it would quietly exclude chasing from "all work." Technically, follow-up has no special exemption.

Yet an organization may still demand visible busyness. Imagine a company that continues to assess response speed, follow-up frequency, and online time rather than settling accounts by results. Zhou's ability to perform the work has been automated. His obligation to demonstrate that he is working has not been withdrawn. Becoming quiet might make him look less diligent than a colleague who keeps posting, "Acknowledged. Monitoring closely."

A peculiar arrangement could persist: AI does the work, AI sends the reminders, AI writes the follow-up report, and a person ensures that all this activity still appears to require their continuous involvement. It may consume few resources yet retain a firm claim on a person's day, because the actual measure is continuous presence.

The title therefore has three conditional answers. **Where handoff and acceptance gaps remain, chasing is work left by incomplete automation. Where scarce resources are allocated by reminders, chasing is competition. Where a system can finish autonomously but the orga-**

nization still measures attendance, chasing may become a performance of labor. All three can coexist in the same company's chat window, while calling for different remedies.

Reducing the first requires better delivery conditions and system design. Reducing the second requires enforceable resource-allocation rules. Reducing the third requires accepting that, once work is done, people need not continue producing signs of work. That last change cannot be achieved by a model upgrade alone. It concerns whether an organization has purchased a result or a claim on someone's availability for the whole day.

At five, Zhou's system finally achieves complete automation. The work has been delivered, the client has accepted it, and all exceptions are closed. He prepares to leave. The attendance page presents a required field: "Describe today's human follow-up activities."

Zhou asks AI to fill it in. AI replies: "Continuously monitored all agents to ensure timely completion of every assignment."

He submits the entry and goes home.

The machines have done all the work, including proving that a human worked today.

Writing note

The topic was proposed by the user. OpenAI Codex assisted with Chinese and English writing, source checking, hypothetical schedule calculations, and layout.

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